

Cuts to weather service worry experts

As firings continue, staff losses could ‘degrade’ forecasts, a climate scientist says.

By Grace Toohey

As Trump administration firings at the National Weather Service continue to impact local offices across the U.S., the agency announced Thursday that staffing limitations may further reduce or suspend the launch of weather balloons. The announcement follows weeks of legal uncertainty over widespread staff reductions, and comes the day after the agency’s Sacramento office announced that it would stop answering public phone lines and reduce the extent and frequency of certain forecasting products due to “critically reduced staffing.” Prior to that announcement, the office said it would be limiting its weather updates on social media. The changes are among the first of many that weather service managers say they are likely to make as they prepare for an era of “degraded operations” under the current administration. “The cracks are really now starting to show,” said Daniel Swain, a UCLA climate scientist. In a discussion about the federal cuts this week, Swain pointed to [See **Weather**, A6]



GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

AFTER NEARLY 20 years in the U.S., Elena says she and her husband will move back to their homeland in Chiapas, Mexico, rather than face the possibility of being detained and marched out like criminals.

A dire choice to ‘self-deport’

More unauthorized immigrants are opting to leave the U.S. on their own terms rather than risk being forced out with nothing

By Rebecca Plevin

Celeste traveled from Peru to the U.S. two decades ago, then a young woman of 19, and overstayed her tourist visa. She had studied graphic design back home but, unable to work in her field without papers, instead found arduous work cleaning hotel rooms and offices in Los Angeles. She built a life here, making friends and taking courses at a local community college. She paid her taxes annually, hoping she could one day gain legal status. But years passed without the dramatic reforms needed to reshape and unclog the legal pathways to U.S. citizenship. And in the months since

President Trump started his second term, her American dream has imploded. She’s unnerved by the news images of undocumented immigrants being loaded onto planes, shackled like violent criminals, and returned to their native countries. The thought of being ripped from her home, without time to pack up her belongings or say goodbye to friends, shakes her to the core. So, Celeste has made a tough decision: She will continue cleaning offices and saving money for just a few more months, and return to Peru by year’s end. Even with a plan to leave, she feels vulnerable and exposed. She now avoids restaurants, her favorite dance spots, even trail hikes. She’s

stopped enrolling in online classes, she said, because she’s apprehensive about registering her name or address. “The fear that they could grab you is always there,” said Celeste, who asked that The Times not use her full name for fear of making her a target for immigration authorities. Trump came into his second term promising the largest deportation effort in U.S. history. During the campaign, he focused his rhetoric on undocumented immigrants who had committed violent crimes. But shortly after he took office, his administration made clear that they considered anyone in the country without authorization to be a criminal. [See **Immigrants**, A7]

\$22.5-million deal OKd in malicious prosecution suit

Six years after defense attorney’s acquittal, Stanislaus County agrees to settlement.

By Christopher Goffard

Six years after a jury acquitted a Modesto defense attorney and his codefendants in an alleged murder conspiracy, Stanislaus County has agreed to settle a malicious prosecution lawsuit for \$22.5 million, one of the largest payouts of its kind in the history of the California courts. County supervisors approved the settlement Tuesday on the threshold of a trial in the federal case, which was brought by eight plaintiffs who contended that po-

lice and prosecutors had fabricated the charges against them. At the heart of the case was the late Frank Carson, a veteran Modesto defense attorney with a pugilistic style who delighted in antagonizing police and prosecutors. The ill feeling toward him at the Stanislaus County district attorney’s office was no secret. In August 2015, after a three-year investigation, the district attorney’s office accused him of masterminding a complicated plot to kill a scrap-metal thief, Korey Kauffman, as revenge for the alleged theft of pipes on Carson’s property. Eight others were charged with helping Carson murder Kauffman or covering up the crime: two brothers who owned a local [See **Settlement**, A7]



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

WORKERS move materials at the site of a home being reconstructed in the Palisades fire zone. Many developers are waiting to see how proposed tariffs play out.

Trump’s tariffs cast a pall over fire rebuilding efforts

Uncertainty over which imports will be targeted is making it difficult to budget.

By Roger Vincent and Liam Dillon

Uncertainty about which imports will be socked with new tariffs and when they’ll go into effect has thrown a cloud over home builders and other real estate developers trying to pay for new construction throughout Southern California, including neighborhoods scorched by the January wildfires. Many builders are trying to budget for rising costs but

are frustrated because they don’t know what construction materials and appliances, such as stoves and air conditioners, will cost in the months ahead. Questions surrounding the tariffs are already forcing contractors to make quick purchasing decisions, especially for windows, doors, plumbing and lighting fixtures and other materials made or manufactured in China, which are subject to duties of 145%. Prices for their customers are already going up. “We’re padding a 5% to 10% contingency for what we’re calling ‘market volatility’ into the budget,” said Cory Singer, a general contractor working on 10 rebuild

projects in Pacific Palisades, including the first home under construction there since fire tore through the neighborhood. He said a tile supplier told him last week that if he didn’t place an order immediately, the new price would be 10% higher, and Singer is telling rebuilding homeowners to prepare for higher costs. The wildfires — which burned an estimated 16,000 homes, businesses and other structures — will ignite a massive construction boom around Los Angeles. But builders were already bracing for material shortages and potentially higher costs for such items [See **Tariffs**, A10]

A BIG LEGAL BLOW TO GOOGLE, BIG TECH

Judge’s monopoly finding against search giant could alter advertising business.

By Queenie Wong

In another major legal blow to Google, a federal judge on Thursday ruled that the search giant held an illegal monopoly over some advertising technology, a ruling that could reshape the online advertising business. Judge Leonie Brinkema of the U.S. District Court for the Eastern District of Virginia said in a decision that Google illegally maintained and acquired a monopoly in two markets for advertising technology — publisher ad servers and the market for ad exchanges. But in a partial win for Google, antitrust enforcers failed to prove that the company held a monopoly in advertiser ad networks, the judge found. The highly anticipated decision could reconfigure the online advertising business rely on to fund the creation of content. It also underscores how the U.S. government has been trying to rein in the power of Big Tech, which collects a trove of data on its users to fuel its advertising businesses. Google’s anticompetitive conduct “substantially harmed Google’s publisher customers, the competitive process, and, ultimately, consumers of information on the open web,” the judge wrote in the 115-page decision. She described digital ads as the “lifeblood of the Internet” that made it possible for people to use some of the world’s most popular websites without paying a subscription fee. The ruling marks the latest legal setback for Google. In August, a judge ruled in a separate case that Google maintained a monopoly in online search. The media industry praised the decision, contending that Google’s mo-

[See **Google**, A10]

Brothers’ bid for freedom stalled

Erik and Lyle Menendez’s resentencing hearing is delayed over a parole board document. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Ohtani’s RBI chances lean

As the Dodgers’ bottom of the order struggles, the leadoff hitter’s production has dropped. **SPORTS, B10**

Outcry over insurer’s actions

Eaton fire victims protest State Farm’s proposed rate hikes, seek probe into alleged delays. **BUSINESS, A9**

Weather
Cloudy and cool.
L.A. Basin: 65/53. **B6**

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